

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).



"I Am" Sayings of Jesus

In the Gospel of John, Jesus often uses the phrase "I am" (in Greek, the phrase is *egō eimi*). Sometimes, Jesus uses this phrase to describe himself. For example, Jesus said, "I am the bread of life." The Gospel of John contains seven statements where Jesus says "I am" followed by a description of himself (John 6:35; 8:12; 10:9, 11; 11:25; 14:6; 15:1).

It is important to note that Greek does not need the pronoun "I" (*egō*) in these sentences. Therefore, using the pronoun emphasizes the speaker's identity. Another example is in the sermon on the mount in the Gospel of Matthew. Jesus says, "You have heard that it was said ... but I [*egō*] tell you" (see Matthew 5:22, 28, 32, 34, 39, 44, and other passages). Including the personal pronoun emphasizes the difference between Jesus' teachings and those of Moses. This phrase emphasizes the unique authority of Jesus.

Sometimes, Jesus used the phrase "I am" in a grammatically unusual way, without anything following it. For example, Jesus said, "Before Abraham was even born, I am" (John 8:58). Before Abraham, Jesus was what? (compare 8:28, 59; 13:19).

The best explanation for this odd expression comes from the Old Testament. When Moses met the Lord on Mount Sinai, he wanted to know God's name (Exodus 3:6, 13-14). God told him that his name is "YHWH," four Hebrew letters that can express existence.

When the Jews translated the Old Testament into Greek, in Exodus 3:14 God's name "I AM WHO I AM" became *egō eimi ho ōn* ("I am the one who is"). In other places, especially in Isaiah 43:25; 51:12; 52:6), the Greek Old Testament uses *egō eimi* ("I am") as a special way God speaks about himself. In many other verses, the Greek translation uses *kurios* ("Lord") for God's name. Some Jews understood Jesus's words "I am" as a claim to God's name, as in John 8:58, where they tried to stone him. But in other places, like John 8:24, they did not react that way and only asked him, "Who are you?"

Jesus not only represents God. The "I Am" statements show Jesus' divine nature, indicating he can work, speak, and act in place of the Father. He is not just a human. He is the Word of God who became human (John 1:1). His voice is the Father's voice, and his life reveals God's life in a human body. The phrase "I Am" powerfully expresses who Jesus is.

Passages for Further Study

John 6:35, 48; 8:12, 58; 9:5; 10:7-14; 11:25; 14:6; 15:1, 5

Infertility

Almost all of the wives of the patriarchs suffered infertility (they were unable to have children) before eventually having children. The only possible exception was Leah, and even she could not have children for some time (Genesis 11:30; 25:21; 29:31; see also 1 Samuel 1:1-18). Children continued the family line, protected the tribe, and provided labor. They guaranteed that property stayed within the family, they had help in old age, and performed proper funeral ceremonies.

Therefore, infertility was a serious disgrace for a woman in that culture (Psalm 113:9; Proverbs 30:15-16; Isaiah 54:1). She understood herself to be created as a vessel of life (Genesis 1:28; 3:20). So, people considered it as a denial of blessing, purpose, and desire (1:28). Infertility brought shame, ridicule, and intense jealousy (1 Samuel 1:7 Genesis 16:4; 30:1).

In the Old Testament, childlessness is an issue related to God. The creator controls fertility (Genesis 20:17-18; 30:2, 22-23; 1 Samuel 1:6, 27). He decides who can have children based on his plans and promises (Genesis 17:19; 30:2; Psalm 113:9; Luke 1:11-20; Romans 4:19). God often used infertility before the birth of a promised or special child, to show it was his work.

Not being able to have children tests patience and encourages prayer and faith (Genesis 25:21; 1 Samuel 1:11). Abraham learned to trust God's promise long before his child was born (Genesis 15:4-6; 17:15-21; Romans 4:20-22). When an infertile couple has a child, it shows God's faithfulness and creative power.

God's delays do not always mean denial. They remind people to use challenges for growth and to appreciate children as gifts. A childless home can focus on devotion to God, accepting his will. Some couples may remain unable to have children for their entire lives. God's people should not isolate those experiencing infertility. Instead, they should offer love and support.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 16:1-6; 17:15-21; 20:17-18; 25:21; 29:31; 30:1-2, 22-24; Exodus 23:25-26; Deuteronomy 7:12-15; Judges 13:2-5; 1 Samuel 1:2-28; 2:5-7; Psalm 113:5-9; Isaiah 54:1-3; Luke 1:5-25; Romans 4:19-22; Galatians 4:24-28; Hebrews 11:11-12

Inheriting the Land

Is the physical world bad? Are spirit, soul, and energy the pure good we seek on our life journey? Will we only

be truly spiritual and happy when we are free from our earthly bodies?

The Bible answers these and similar questions with an emphatic “No!” The universe, including earth and all living creatures, came from the skilled hand of a loving creator. He considered it “very good” (Genesis 1:31). Because of human sin, this physical world needs redemption. By God’s grace, it will share in God’s redemption at the end of time (see Romans 8:19–21).

Scripture shows the goodness and importance of the world with a focus on what God says about land. All land belongs to God. God removed the Canaanite people from the promised land because of their evil. He brought Israel into that land because of his promises to the Israelite patriarchs. He also wants humans to care for the earth in harmony with its creator.

In ancient Israel, each household received a portion on which to live. God’s assignment of the land, not the land itself, was what he entrusted for them to manage. Fathers passed this land assignment to their sons as the main part of family inheritances.

Following these principles and God’s instructions, Joshua divided the land among the tribes. The tribes then divided it among clans, families, and individual households. God’s gift of management over a specific land portion was essentially a gift of life to each household.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 1:31; 12:7; 13:14–17; 15:12–21; 17:7–8; 35:11–13; 50:24; Joshua 13:1–21:45; Psalm 37:9–34; Luke 12:22–34; 16:9–11

Intermarriage and Divorce

God had warned his people not to marry foreigners (Deuteronomy 7:1–6). The problem was not marrying someone from another country or race. The issue was marrying people who followed other gods. Moses himself married a Cushite woman (Numbers 12:1). Other foreigners joined Israel through marriage, like Rahab the Canaanite and Ruth the Moabite (see Matthew 1:5; Ruth 4:1–22). These women trusted in God, and God blessed them. However, King Solomon married many foreign wives. Their devotion to other gods influenced him to worship idols, just as God had previously warned his people would happen (1 Kings 11:1–5).

In the Bible, marriage is viewed as a binding promise (or covenant) made before God. This covenant includes commitments to faithfulness, love, and loyalty between the married couple. But it was even more important for Israel to remain faithful to the Lord’s

covenant with them as a people. Mixed marriages could produce children not fully committed to Israel’s faith. They would become influenced by the idolatry of their foreign parent. This compromise would cause Israel to become totally unfaithful to God and embrace false religions, as they did before the exile to Babylon (see Judges 3:3–7; 14:1–9; 1 Kings 11:1–8; 2 Kings 17:7–17).

In Ezra 9 and 10, the Jews who returned from exile married people who worshipped other gods. Ezra’s solution was divorce, but this is not a rule for Christians today. In the new covenant under Christ, the faith of a Christian makes his or her marriage and children acceptable before God. Because of this, marriage to an unbeliever does not threaten the identity or purity of God’s people (1 Corinthians 7:14–16). Paul recognized that marriage between believers and unbelievers could be difficult and might end in separation. However, he told Christians not to seek divorce if the unbelieving spouse was willing to remain married (1 Corinthians 7:10–13).

To avoid these issues, it is wise to follow Paul’s advice for believers not to marry unbelievers. God’s people should stay separate from what is unholy: “For what partnership can righteousness have with wickedness? Or what fellowship does light have with darkness? What harmony is there between Christ and Belial? Or what does a believer have in common with an unbeliever?” (2 Corinthians 6:14–15). Yet, those married to an unbeliever today have God’s assurance that God can use that difficult situation for his glory (see also 1 Peter 3:1–2).

Passages for Further Study

Deuteronomy 7:1–6; Joshua 2:1–14; 6:23–25; Judges 3:3–7; 14:1–9; Ruth 4:1–22; 1 Kings 11:1–8; 2 Kings 17:7–17; Ezra 9:1–10:44; 1 Corinthians 7:10–16; 2 Corinthians 6:14–15; Hebrews 11:31

Invasion

In the ancient world, foreign invasions were common. They caused great difficulty. If invaders succeeded, they brought destruction and suffering. Victorious invaders killed adult men, raped women, enslaved children, stole valuables, and destroyed everything else. The threat of invasion made the people afraid.

In the final decades of the kingdom, the people of Judah and Jerusalem lived under the threat of Babylon’s conquest. Over a century earlier, the Assyrians had destroyed the northern kingdom of Israel, invaded Judah, and attacked Jerusalem. These events stayed clearly in the memories of the people of Judah. The

prophet Jeremiah warned of another coming invasion and the destruction it would cause.

When invasion threatened, people wanted to find ways to avoid the coming suffering. Prophets like Jeremiah urged God's people to abandon false gods and obey the Lord. They advised against relying on powerful allies for rescue. Instead, they encouraged seeking the Lord's protection.

The prophets sometimes described in detail what would happen during an invasion. Their goal was not to scare or discourage God's people. God sent them to encourage obedience to him. They wanted people to trust in the Lord for salvation and experience his rescue. This is how King Hezekiah reacted to the Assyrian invasion a century earlier. He trusted the Lord, and the Lord rescued him and his people.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 14:1–16; 2 Kings 17:5–23; 18:13–19:37; Isaiah 6:8–13; 36:1–37:38; 65:21–23; Jeremiah 6:22–26; 19:7–15

Israel's Geography as Theology

The division of the land in Ezekiel 47:13–48:35 combines spiritual ideals with a practical message. It reinforces themes from earlier parts of the vision (Ezekiel 40–46). The prophet Ezekiel envisioned a future closely linked to the past. The land of Israel remained the special land promised to Israel's patriarchs.

The map in this vision is different from the earlier tribal divisions in Joshua's time. In Ezekiel's vision, each tribe receives an equal portion of land. These portions are in east-to-west strips. They align the entire land with the temple at its center. These strips do not match the actual geography of the land. They are symbolic. The idea is that old tribal rivalries and hatreds will disappear, as each tribe will have equal status.

The monarchy (the system of being ruled by God's chosen king) is not abolished in this vision, but it is transformed. The ruined city from earlier chapters of Ezekiel becomes a new holy city of unity and harmony for the tribes. A life-giving river restores, bringing blessings from God's temple to every part of the people's lives.

The vision in Ezekiel 40–48 encourages people to repent for past sins, stay faithful in difficult times, and hope for a better future through God's power and grace. The final chapters of Revelation show this vision fulfilled in Jesus (Revelation 21–22). Jesus began the spiritual reality Ezekiel described. It is a heavenly city "whose architect and builder is God" (Hebrews 11:10).

Passages for Further Study

Ezekiel 40:1–46:24; 47:13–48:35; Revelation 22:1–2